Wickedgood Candle Return

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Executive Summary

Problem

Candles are a popular product, especially as gifts, but when a candle is finished the jar is usually thrown in the trash. Many candle jars are made of good quality glass that could be used many more times. Because there is no easy way to send them back, most people either throw them out or keep a few around the house as storage. This creates unnecessary waste and is a growing concern for people who care about the environment. At the same time, small candle makers want to be more sustainable but they are busy making and selling candles. They do not have the time, space, or money to set up their own system for collecting, cleaning and reusing jars. Customers who want to do the right thing also have no easy way to see the impact of their choices. We believe this is a real problem that affects both buyers and sellers of candles.

Solution

Wickedgood Candle Return is a reuse program that makes returning candle jars simple. Our solution has three parts.

First, a prepaid mailer. A candle maker who partners with us includes a prepaid return mailer in the box with each candle order, or customers can request one from us. When the candle is finished the customer puts the empty jar in the mailer and drops it in the mail.

Second, cleaning and refilling. When jars arrive at our workspace we remove leftover wax, wash and sanitize the glass, inspect it for chips and cracks, and then send good jars back to the candle maker, who refills them with fresh wax and sells them again.

Third, a data dashboard. Each customer and each candle maker can log in to see how many jars have been returned, how much glass waste was avoided, and an estimate of the carbon saved. We think this makes the impact feel real and gives candle makers something to share with their own customers.

Market

The candle market is large and growing. Candles are sold in grocery stores, gift shops, online shops and at craft markets. Our focus is on two groups. The first is eco-minded gift buyers, who often choose products based on values and are willing to pay a bit more for something sustainable. The second is small and independent candle makers, who number in the thousands across the country and sell mostly online and at local markets. We estimate that if even a small share of these makers joined our program, we could handle a very large number of jars each year. We have not yet done a detailed market sizing, but we believe the growing interest in sustainability and reuse means demand will continue to increase.

Business Model

We plan to make money in a few ways. Candle makers would pay us a fee for each jar that is returned, cleaned and sent back to them. Customers may also pay a small fee for the mailer when it is not included by the candle maker. In the future we could offer premium dashboard features to candle makers, such as more detailed reports they can use in marketing. We have not finalized our prices. Our early thinking is that a fee per jar would be lower than the cost of buying new jars, which would make the program attractive to candle makers, but we still need to test this. Our costs include the mailers, postage, cleaning supplies, labor and the software for the dashboard. We expect that as we handle more jars our cost per jar will come down.

Competition

There are other reuse and return programs in the market, and some larger candle brands have

started offering refills for their own products. There are also general packaging reuse services that work with many kinds of products. What makes us different is that we focus only on candles and on small makers, and we include a data dashboard so that customers can see their impact. We believe a focused service is easier for small makers to use than a general one. Large brands run their own programs and are not likely to serve small makers. We think our biggest competition is really customers doing nothing, because returning a jar takes effort and many people will not bother.

Team

Maya Lindqvist is a junior studying environmental science and leads operations and partnerships. She has experience running a campus recycling drive. Derrick Okonkwo-Hale is a senior studying industrial design and leads the physical product, including the mailer and the cleaning process. Priya Venkataraman is a junior studying information systems and builds the dashboard and handles the data. We are all students at our university and work on this alongside our classes. We have not yet added any advisors, but we plan to look for mentors with experience in consumer products and logistics.

Milestones and Financials

So far we have defined our core business concept, built a prototype, and gotten our first external users. Our prototype includes a basic mailer design, a simple cleaning process we developed in a shared kitchen space, and a first version of the dashboard. We have had a small number of friends, family and a few local candle makers try the program, and early feedback has been positive. People said the idea was interesting and that they liked seeing the dashboard. We have not yet formed a legal entity and we do not have a website. We have not generated meaningful revenue. Our spending so far has been small and paid by the founders. In the next year we hope to form a company, sign up several more candle makers, process a few thousand jars, and begin charging fees. We expect to reach break-even once we have enough partners, but we have not built a detailed financial model yet.

What We Are Asking For

We are asking for prize funding from the competition to help us take the next steps. We would use the money to form a legal entity, build a simple website, buy a larger supply of mailers and cleaning equipment, and run a pilot with more candle makers. We would also like to receive mentorship and introductions to people in sustainable consumer products, shipping and small business. Finally, feedback from the judges would help us improve our plan and decide on our pricing. We believe Wickedgood Candle Return can make reuse easy for candle lovers and help small makers be more sustainable, and this competition would help us get started.